

that he would probably have excelled in any field. His happy childhood was followed by a happy married life, with a beautiful wife and five children. However, fate dealt him cruel blows in later life with the unexpected death of his beloved sister and, soon afterward, his own death at the age of 38.

“This year [is] an **important segment** in our family life. **Felix, our soul, is going away.**”

FANNY MENDELSSOHN, DIARY ENTRY, JANUARY 1,
1829

A precocious talent

Mendelssohn came from a Jewish family whose most notable member was philosopher Moses Mendelssohn, his paternal grandfather. His father was a banker and his mother, an excellent amateur pianist, also came from a banking family. In 1822, his parents converted from Judaism to Protestantism; to show their new allegiance, they added the name “Bartholdy” (from a Christian branch of the family) to their own. Thus the composer is sometimes known as Felix Mendelssohn-Bartholdy.

Felix was born in 1809 in Hamburg, the second of four children, and grew up in Berlin. All four children were highly intelligent and had great musical talent, but Felix and his elder sister, Fanny, were exceptional in this regard, seeming to master all aspects of the subject with ease. Felix gave his first public performance as a pianist at the age